

Lab602: Stakeholder Interview Game

Marco Martins

1. Pain Point Discovery Table

Based on the stakeholder interview transcript from the consulting firm client health monitoring project:

Persona Name	Pain Point	How This Affects the Project
Jennifer Park (VP Account Management, Project Sponsor)	No early warning system for client churn. Signals exist across disconnected tools (Gmail, Jira, Slack, Calendar) but there's no unified view. By the time the team knows a client is unhappy, it's already too late—often discovering churn risk only when the client announces they're leaving. Currently takes 4-12 weeks to detect a client at risk; needs this reduced to less than 1 week.	The system must integrate data from at least 4 separate tools (Gmail, Jira, Slack, Google Calendar) into a single unified dashboard. Requires real-time data aggregation and a predictive health scoring algorithm with minimum 75% accuracy. Dashboard must load in under 1 minute and clearly show red/yellow/green status for all 50+ accounts. Need automated alerts when health scores drop below risk thresholds, targeting 1-day response time instead of weeks.
Conal (CEO, Executive Stakeholder)	No visibility into revenue risk and no data-driven forecasting capability. Revenue forecasts are currently based on gut feeling rather than client health signals. Cannot see which accounts represent the highest financial exposure or track whether recovery interventions actually work. Spends too much time being reactive to	Requires a dashboard that correlates health scores directly to revenue exposure per client, allowing prioritization by business impact. Must implement intervention tracking functionality so the executive team can see what recovery actions were taken and whether they led to client retention. The system needs to generate churn probability forecasts

Persona Name	Pain Point	How This Affects the Project
	client crises instead of proactively managing risk.	in a 4-12 week window with revenue impact clearly displayed. Success means the CEO can forecast accurately and see recovery plans before clients churn, not after.
Marscha Thompson (Senior Account Manager)	Spends excessive time on manual client monitoring (half to full day per week) and struggles to objectively assess client sentiment.	The system must provide AI-based sentiment analysis of client communications (email, Slack) with explicit privacy controls—no raw message content exposed to other employees. Need automated early warning signals that track: email response time delays, missed/canceled meetings, project delays relative to scope, and communication tone shifts (friendly → terse). Must create a unified client timeline view aggregating all touchpoints across tools so Marscha doesn't have to manually switch between Gmail, Slack, Jira, and Calendar. Goal: reduce manual monitoring time to under 2 hours per week for all accounts while increasing accuracy of risk detection.
	Manages 12-15 high-value clients with intense relationships. Wastes significant effort trying to schedule calls, chase secretaries, and arrange dinners just to check in.	
	Cannot reliably tell if clients are actually unhappy—sometimes reads politeness as satisfaction, then the client churns 2 weeks later. Has identified correlation signals (email response time, meeting cancellations, project timeline slippage, tone changes) but has no systematic way to track them.	
Nadia Alvarez (Account Manager, Junior)	Wastes time contacting all 8-10 clients equally every day because she doesn't know which ones actually need attention.	Dashboard must support role-based access control—Nadia should only see her assigned 8-10 accounts, not the full company portfolio. Requires a daily prioritized action list feature that shows "contact these 2-3 clients today" based on health signals, eliminating the need to blindly check in with everyone. System must provide clear context for each alert (e.g., "Client hasn't responded to email in 5 days + missed last
	New to the role, relies heavily on frameworks and structure but lacks the experience to intuitively prioritize. Sends weekly reports and schedules standing calls with everyone, even clients who are perfectly fine. Gets confused when clients	

Persona Name	Pain Point	How This Affects the Project
	seem happy in calls but then drop off 2 weeks later—cannot distinguish genuine satisfaction from polite deflection.	meeting") so she understands <i>why</i> she needs to act, not just <i>that</i> she needs to act. Success means she spends time strengthening relationships that need it, not wasting effort on healthy accounts.

1.1 Additional Pain Points Discovered Across Multiple Stakeholders

Pain Point Theme	Evidence from Interview	Impact on Project Requirements
Scope Creep is Undetected Until Unprofitable	Marscha: "Sometimes there's scope creeps, so I'll do a proposal, send it out for them, and then they're adding stuff and adding stuff, and it ends up with the team, our team, getting paid, unpaid for extra hours of work". Jennifer: "the project scope might creep", "something that hopefully helps with the scope creep"	System must monitor active projects against original scope/budget/timeline using Jira data. Flag when projects deviate from agreed parameters as a client health risk signal. Scope creep is both a profitability issue AND an early indicator that the relationship dynamics are deteriorating.
Multi-stakeholder Complexity Within Client Organizations	Jennifer: "we don't want to expose our personal sentiments, you know, analysis to other employees, so there must be some kind of... multiple stakeholders, right? Um, like, decision maker versus day-to-day contact"	Support tracking multiple contacts per client with role differentiation (decision-maker vs. operational contact). Sentiment signals may need different weighting depending on who the communication is with—a terse email from a decision-maker is more critical than one from a junior operational contact.
Meeting No-Shows Are Critical Warning Signals	Marscha: "we're sometimes just happy that they even show up", "some of them canceled meetings, and then they left us. So we see that there's a correlation	Meeting attendance is mentioned repeatedly and deserves higher prominence in health scoring algorithm. Meeting no-shows/cancellations

	there", "I'm even happy to share my calendar with you. As I mentioned several times, people just don't even show up sometimes"	should potentially trigger immediate yellow alerts, not just contribute to an overall score. Pattern of 2+ consecutive cancellations could be an automatic escalation trigger.
No Defined Success Metrics for Client Value Delivery	Carolina asked: "How do you measure the value that your firm is bringing to your clients?" Team response: Long pause, then Jennifer: "It means it's not in the brief". This was a gap in their current process.	While not directly part of the churn prediction system, this reveals a deeper strategic gap: they have no proactive value measurement, only reactive churn detection. The system should eventually support tracking client outcomes/wins/successes as positive health signals, not just negative risk indicators. Consider future enhancement to log client wins, successful deliverables, or positive feedback as counterbalancing signals.

1.2 Key Patterns Observed

1. **Information Scattered Across Tools:** Every stakeholder mentioned the fragmentation problem—data exists in Gmail, Slack, Jira, Calendar, and survey tools, but nobody is connecting the dots.
2. **Time Waste on Manual Monitoring:** Marscha spends "half to a day a week" on 12-15 clients; Nadia contacts all 8-10 daily; Jennifer mentioned "more than 2 hours per week" overhead across the team. Current total: unclear, but estimated 10-15+ hours/week across all AMs.
3. **Gut Feeling vs. Data:** Multiple stakeholders (Conal, Jennifer, Marscha) emphasized they rely on intuition and experience, which fails them—clients churn despite "seeming fine" in recent conversations.
4. **Reactive vs. Proactive:** Conal explicitly stated he wants to "spend less time being reactive and more time being proactive" (14:37:05). Current state: they fight fires. Desired state: they prevent fires.
5. **Signals Exist But Aren't Captured:** The team has identified correlation patterns empirically (email delays, meeting cancellations, tone

changes, project slippage) but has no systematic tracking, scoring, or alerting based on these signals.

2. Interview Notes and Questions Used

2.1 Overview Stakeholder Interview

Interviewer Team: Marco Martins, Carolina Nami, Antonio Ciraci, Artem, Dina Bosma-Buczynska

Stakeholder Team: Jennifer Park (VP Account Management), Conal (CEO), Marscha Thompson (Senior Account Manager), Nadia Alvarez (Account Manager)

Project Context: Client health monitoring and churn prevention system for consulting firm managing 50+ enterprise clients

Duration: Approximately 56 minutes

2.2 Questions Asked and Responses

2.2.1 Opening & Context Setting Questions

Question	Asked By	Stakeholder Response	Effectiveness
"Can you present yourself and tell me what you do?"	Marco	Each stakeholder introduced themselves. Jennifer: VP overseeing 50+ clients. Marscha: Senior AM managing 12-15 high-value clients. Nadia: New AM managing 8-10 clients. Conal: CEO focused on revenue and risk.	Effective. Got clear role definitions and initial priorities. Revealed organizational hierarchy.

"What exactly does your company do?"	Marco	Jennifer: "Consulting firm managing enterprise client relationships." Marscha: Work in fintech, healthcare, FMCG, banking.	Somewhat vague. Had to follow up multiple times. Could have asked: "Can you give me an example of a typical client engagement?"
"What is the main focus for the team?"	Marco	Marscha: "We focus on consulting, provide services...we're all client-facing on the sales side."	Too broad. Got generic answer. Should have asked about specific daily activities instead.

2.2.2 Process & Workflow Questions

Question	Asked By	Stakeholder Response	Effectiveness
"Walk me through your current process for onboarding new clients?"	Carolina	Marscha: Marketing → leads → follow up → relationship building → onboard to system. Jennifer added: sales handoff → project setup, but biggest challenge is client churn monitoring.	Very effective. Process question naturally led to pain point revelation about churn detection.
"What tasks take most of your time each week?"	Carolina	Marscha: "Manually checking in with clients is quite time-consuming...trying to understand if they're happy or not is not as easy as it sounds." Conal: "Most important goal is no surprises."	Excellent. Time-based question immediately exposed inefficiency pain point and strategic priority.

"How do you track if client projects are on track or falling behind?"	Carolina	Nadia: "We just have our internal frameworks." Jennifer: "Time to detect a risk client is more than a week...ideally improve retention rate by 5% year-over-year."	Good. Revealed lack of systematic tracking and specific success metrics (5% retention, 4.3/5 survey score).
"How do you prepare for a client meeting to make sure it's successful?"	Carolina	Marscha: "Honestly, we're sometimes just happy that they even show up...do they answer our emails? Are they responding at all?"	Excellent indirect discovery. Question about preparation revealed major pain: clients don't show up, don't respond.

2.2.3 Time & Efficiency Questions

Question	Asked By	Stakeholder Response	Effectiveness
"If you had an extra hour each day at work, what would you focus on instead?"	Antonio	Conal: "I would love our account managers spend more time strengthening relationships, not reacting to crisis." Marscha: "Spend more time on high-value clients rather than getting new ones."	Brilliant question. Revealed current state (crisis mode) vs. desired state (proactive relationship building).
"How much time do you spend each week reaching out to clients?"	Antonio	Marscha: "I probably spend half to a day a week...because I have 15 clients and I do it quarterly."	Excellent. Got specific time estimate (4-8 hours/week) and revealed

		But it takes a lot of effort to get ahold of them."	frustration with client availability.
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2.2.4 Data & Reporting Questions

Question	Asked By	Stakeholder Response	Effectiveness
"How are you reporting on client health to your CEO?"	Carolina	Marscha: "Annual health check survey...some statistics on churn which could be good or not accurate." Jennifer: "Ideally we wanted to have a dashboard but we don't have that."	Very effective. Revealed gap between current state (annual survey, inaccurate stats) and desired state (real-time dashboard).
"Do you send surveys to your customers?"	Antonio	Marscha: "We do send a yearly client survey once a year."	Good confirmation. Established baseline: only annual feedback, no ongoing sentiment tracking.
"How do you currently track how responsive the client is?"	Antonio	Conal: "Right now is direct report." Marscha: "I spend quite a lot of time trying one by one to contact my clients...quite time-consuming."	Effective. Confirmed no automated tracking, purely manual effort.

2.2.5 Signal & Indicator Questions

Question	Asked By	Stakeholder Response	Effectiveness
"What are those early signals? Where do you gather that information?"	Dina	Jennifer: Current workflow = manual quarterly check-ins, project status from Jira only for active projects, no systematic satisfaction tracking, churn only discovered when client says "I don't want to work with you anymore."	Excellent. Got full picture of current broken workflow.
"What are those early signals that could be an indicator already?"	Dina	Marscha: Email response time, canceled meetings (correlation with churn), tone in emails (friendly vs. short/abrupt), timeline slippage on client deliverables.	Gold mine. Stakeholder volunteered specific signals they've empirically observed. These became core requirements.
"When you receive information from different tools, what do you usually need to double check?"	Antonio	Marscha: Has to remind clients about proposals, chase scope creep ("they're adding stuff and it ends up with the team getting unpaid for extra hours of work"), inform about at-risk projects.	Great question. Uncovered scope creep pain point that wasn't initially obvious.

2.2.6 Success & Vision Questions

Question	Asked By	Stakeholder Response	Effectiveness
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"Can you describe the success in 6 months?"	Artem	Marscha: "Better visibility on most important clients, indications of unhappiness, dashboard showing where to focus time, ultimately having less clients leave." Jennifer: "Churn prediction accuracy >75%, AM confidence 4.3/5, alert accuracy >80%, <2 hours/week monitoring for 50 accounts."	Extremely effective. Got specific, measurable success criteria. This became the success metrics table in requirements.
"What information would help you detect client risk earlier? Is there anything you wish you had right now?"	Antonio	Conal: "I would love to have a uniform score of percentage of churn predictability and mitigation actions the team is taking...a place where I can see everything and make decisions."	Excellent. Vision question revealed executive-level needs: unified view, churn score, recovery tracking.

2.2.7 Clarification & Deep-Dive Questions

Question	Asked By	Stakeholder Response	Effectiveness
"How often do you check in with a client on a regular basis? Is one week realistic?"	Dina	Marscha: "Different for every client and project, but touchpoints themselves are similar." Jennifer: "More than 2 hours per week just on ad hoc client monitoring."	Good reality check. Clarified ambiguity between check-in frequency and detection speed goals.
"Do you have any indicators for understanding the health score or do	Artem	Jennifer: "That's something we have to set up. Ideally prediction rate of churning >75%." Marscha: "We noticed	Important clarification. Confirmed they have observed

we need to create these for you?"		clients not answering emails quickly, not showing up for meetings."	correlations but no formal health score model.
"What are the metrics for red, yellow, and green? When is something a red alert?"	Dina	Conal: "They take too long to respond." Jennifer: "It needs context analysis...did they specifically say they're unhappy...prediction math...sentiment in communication."	Partially answered. They have intuitions but no formal thresholds. This became an "open question" in requirements doc.
"How do you measure the value that your firm is bringing to your clients?"	Carolina	[Long pause] Jennifer: "It means it's not in the brief."	Great question but not in scope. Revealed strategic gap in business model but not directly related to churn prediction system.

2.2.8 Questions About Priorities & Constraints

Question	Asked By	Stakeholder Response	Effectiveness
"How do you give priority to a client? Do you have a way, or just a sense?"	Antonio	Team member: "For revenue, I think." Jennifer: "The challenge is project scope might creep...we're having a hard time with the focus part...monitor if we're progressing, delaying, going beyond project scope."	Effective. Confirmed revenue-based prioritization and uncovered additional pain point (scope creep monitoring).

"Do you have any priorities for all these tasks? What do we need to realize first vs. second?"	Artem	Jennifer: "I couldn't say priorities, it's more like everybody said their main goals...for me it's revenue and retention. For account managers it's monitoring." Conal: "What's risking the revenue and the recovery plans."	Somewhat unclear answer. Could have asked: "If you could only have ONE feature in month 1, what would it be?"
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2.2.9 Problem-Focused Questions

Question	Asked By	Stakeholder Response	Effectiveness
"What is the kind of tasks that you really don't want to do anymore? You arrive Sunday afternoon and feel 'oh no, not another week doing that?'"	Marco	Marscha: "It's very hard to check in with all 12-15 clients...very frustrating when they leave." Jennifer: "Information/signals exist in so many tools...would be nice to have something I just go and check daily...scope creep."	Excellent emotional question. "Sunday afternoon dread" framing made it feel less like direct pain point question and got authentic emotional responses.

2.3 Key Observations from Interview Flow

2.3.1 What Worked Well

1. Time-based questions were highly effective
 - o "How much time do you spend..." consistently revealed inefficiency pain points
 - o Stakeholders gave specific numbers (half-day/week, 2+ hours/week)
2. Process walkthrough questions opened up natural pain point discussions

- "Walk me through onboarding..." led Jennifer to volunteer "biggest challenge is client churn"
- Process questions feel safe, so stakeholders are more open
- 3. **"Extra hour" hypothetical was brilliant**
 - Revealed what they're NOT doing now (proactive relationship building)
 - Showed gap between current reactive state and desired proactive state
- 4. **Follow-up questions were strong**
 - Team didn't just accept first answer
 - Dina's follow-ups on signals were particularly effective
 - Example: After getting vague answer about challenges, team pivoted to ask about specific workflows
- 5. **Success vision questions yielded concrete metrics**
 - "Describe success in 6 months" got measurable targets (75% accuracy, 4.3/5 score, <2 hrs/week)
 - These became the success metrics table directly
- 6. **Multiple interviewers worked well**
 - Different people asked follow-ups from different angles
 - Carolina focused on process, Antonio on time/efficiency, Artem on priorities, Dina on details

2.3.2 What Could Be Improved

1. **Some opening questions were too broad**
 - "What is the main focus?" got generic "we do consulting" answer
 - Better: "Can you walk me through what you did yesterday?" or "What's a typical client engagement?"
2. **Didn't dig deep enough on scope creep initially**
 - Jennifer mentioned it 3 times throughout the interview
 - Marscha described unpaid work due to scope creep
 - Could have asked: "How often does this happen? What's the financial impact? How do you currently try to prevent it?"
3. **Could have explored tool integration pain earlier**
 - Jennifer mentioned Gmail, Jira, Slack, Calendar mid-interview
 - Could have immediately asked: "Walk me through what happens when you need to check on one client—which tools do you open and in what order?"
4. **Missed opportunity on sentiment analysis specifics**

- Marscha said she misreads tone (sometimes thinks clients are happy, then they drop after 2 weeks)
 - Could have asked: "Can you give me an example of a time you misread a client? What did they say that seemed fine but wasn't?"
- 5. Priority clarification was weak**
- When asked about priorities, got vague answer
 - Should have asked: "If you had to launch with just ONE dashboard view in month 1, what would you want to see on it?"
- 6. Didn't explore historical data availability early enough**
- Only came up when Conal asked if we could build an adaptive model
 - Should have asked in first 15 minutes: "What data do you currently capture? How far back does it go?"

2.3.3 Questions That Didn't Work

Question	Why It Failed	Better Alternative
"What is your main focus?"	Too vague, got generic answer about "consulting services"	"What did you spend most of your time on this week?" or "What meetings are on your calendar this week?"
"Do you have priorities?"	Too abstract, stakeholders couldn't/wouldn't rank	"If we could only deliver ONE thing in the first release, what would make the biggest difference to your daily work?"
"How do you measure value to clients?"	Outside their current thinking—they admitted it's not tracked	"When a client renews, what do they usually say was most valuable about working with you?"

2.4 Interview Technique Patterns

2.4.1 Successful Question Patterns

1. Time quantification: "How much time...", "How long does it take..."
2. Process walkthrough: "Walk me through...", "What does a typical [X] look like..."
3. Hypothetical reallocation: "If you had an extra hour...", "What would you do instead..."
4. Success definition: "What would success look like...", "Describe success in 6 months..."
5. Signal hunting: "What do you notice when...", "What patterns have you seen..."
6. Emotional framing: "Sunday afternoon dread", "What keeps you up at night..."

2.4.2 Question Sequences That Worked

Sequence 1: Process → Pain Point

1. "Walk me through your current onboarding process" (Carolina)
2. Stakeholder describes process naturally
3. Jennifer volunteers: "But the biggest challenge is client churn"
4. Pain point revealed without direct asking

Sequence 2: Time → Inefficiency → Desired State

1. "How much time do you spend reaching out to clients?" (Antonio)
2. Marscha: "Half to a day a week"
3. "If you had an extra hour each day, what would you focus on?" (Antonio)
4. Conal: "Strengthening relationships, not reacting to crisis"
5. Current waste → Desired outcome mapped

Sequence 3: Current State → Signals → Root Cause

1. "How do you track client health now?" (Carolina)
2. Stakeholder: "Annual survey, inaccurate churn stats"
3. "What early signals exist?" (Dina)
4. Marscha: Lists email response time, meeting cancellations, tone changes
5. Gap between signals observed and systematic tracking revealed

2.5 Key Learnings for Future Interviews

Do More Of

- Ask time quantification questions early
- Use "walk me through" process questions
- Ask about a typical day/week
- Use hypothetical reallocation ("extra hour")
- Ask for success definition with specific metrics
- Look for patterns in stakeholder language (what they repeat)
- Build question chains (answer A → question B → answer C)
- Ask for specific examples when answers are abstract
- Show empathy and understanding in question framing

Do Less Of

- Avoid broad abstract questions ("What is your main focus?")
- Don't ask about priorities without forcing mechanism
- Don't jump to solutions before understanding current state
- Don't ask technical details before establishing context
- Don't let interesting tangents derail core discovery (know when to move on)

2.5.1 New Techniques to Try Next Time

- "Day in the life" opening instead of company overview
- "Have you tried to solve this before? What happened?"
- "What workarounds have you created?"
- Forced-choice prioritization questions
- "Tell me about a specific time when [X happened]" for concrete stories
- "Which tools do you open and in what order?" for workflow granularity
- Establish historical data availability in first 15 minutes

3. Final Reflection: Key takeaways

1. Indirect questioning is a skill that requires practice
 - It's not intuitive to ask about time instead of problems
 - This exercise forced that muscle memory
2. Good requirements come from good questions

- The quality of our user stories and requirements directly correlates to the quality of questions we asked
- Missing questions = missing requirements (e.g., scope creep)
- 3. Stakeholders reveal more when they feel understood
 - Empathy in questioning (Sunday afternoon dread) worked better than clinical questioning
 - Building rapport matters
- 4. Multiple interviews/angles are necessary
 - One question rarely reveals everything
 - Question chains and follow-ups are essential
 - Different interviewer styles complement each other
- 5. Documentation matters
 - Taking notes during the interview captured specific metrics and examples
 - Real interviews: always record (with permission) or have a dedicated note-taker